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Dubai to Riyadh one of busiest flight routes

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai-Riyadh has ranked among the top 10 busiest international flight routes in the world in 2025, proving there is strong and growing travel demand between the UAE and Saudi Arabia.

According to a new report by aviation data firm OAG, the route recorded 4.5 million scheduled seats this year, up 4 per cent from 2024 and 42 per cent higher than pre-pandemic levels in 2019, placing it seventh globally among international routes.

Nine of the world's ten busiest airline routes in 2025 are located in the Asia-Pacific region, highlighting the region's continued dominance in global aviation.

The topper

The Jeju-Seoul Gimpo route in South Korea topped the global rankings, with 14.4 million seats scheduled this year, though it is still trailing pre-pandemic levels.

Alongside Dubai-Riyadh, another Middle East route made the global top rankings. Cairo-Jeddah ranked as the second busiest international route globally, with 5.8 million seats. Capacity on the route is 71 per cent higher than in 2019.

Saudi Arabia's busiest domestic route, Jeddah-Riyadh, was the fastest-growing route in the global Top 10, with capacity up 13 per cent year-on-year to 9.8 million seats.

Pope calls for peace through dialogue in Christmas blessing

LEO REMEMBERS THOSE WHO HAVE LOST EVERYTHING, LIKE PEOPLE IN GAZA

VATICAN CITY

Pope Leo XIV during his first Christmas Day message yesterday urged the faithful to shed indifference in the face of those who have lost everything, like in Gaza, those who are in impoverished and the many migrants who cross the Mediterranean Sea and the American continent for a better future.

The first US pontiff addressed some 26,000 people from the loggia overlooking St Peter's Square for the traditional papal "Urbi et Orbi" address, Latin for "To the City and to the World," which serves as a summary of the woes facing the world.

While the crowd gathered under a steady downpour during the papal Mass inside St Peter's basilica, the rain had subsided by the time Leo took a brief tour of the square in the popemobile, then spoke to the crowd from the loggia.

Humility and responsibility

Leo revived the tradition of offering Christmas greetings in multiple languages abandoned by his predecessor, Pope Francis. During the traditional address, the pope emphasised that everyone could contribute to peace by acting with humility and responsibility.

"If he would truly enter into the suffering of others and stand in solidarity with the weak and the oppressed, then the world would change," the pope said.

Leo called for "justice, peace and stability" in Lebanon, Palestine, Israel and Syria, prayers



■ Pope Leo XIV waves to the faithful as he arrives aboard the popemobile ahead of addressing the Urbi et Orbi message and blessing to the city and the world at St Peter's Square yesterday.

for "the tormented people of Ukraine," and "peace and consolation" for victims of wars, injustice, political stability, religious persecution and terrorism.

Earlier, Leo led the Christmas Day Mass from the central altar beneath the balustrade of St Peter's Basilica, adorned with floral garlands and clusters of red poinsettias. White flowers were set at the feet of a statue of Mary, mother of Jesus, whose birth is celebrated on Christmas Day.

In his homily, Leo underlined that peace can emerge only through dialogue. "There will be peace when our monologues are interrupted and, enriched by

listening, we fall to our knees before the humanity of the other," he said.

'Defenceless populations'

He remembered the people of Gaza, "exposed for weeks to rain, wind and cold" and the fragility of "defenceless populations, tried by so many wars," and of "young people forced to take up arms, who on the front lines feel the senselessness of what is asked of them, and the falsehoods that fill the pompous speeches of those who send them to their deaths."

Meanwhile, Christmas was celebrated across the world yes-

terday with great fervour, devotion and joy, as churches resonated with hymns, prayers and messages of peace, love and unity.

It was also celebrated in regions that are recovering from the horrors of war and violence.

In Bethlehem, the Christian community celebrated its first festive Christmas in more than two years as the occupied West Bank city emerges from the shadow of the war in Gaza.

In Syria, Christmas lights illuminated Damascus's Old City despite the Christian community's fears of violence after a deadly attack in June.

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